



Driving the point home: Head physio, Rajasthan Royals, John Gloster (extreme right), emphasises his point while Vijay Sharma, the National weightlifting coach, along with Dr. Amit Bhattacharjee, a Scientist at PGIMER, Chandigarh, and Dr. Tvisha Parikh, a Sports physician at Sir H. N. Reliance Foundation Hospital, attentively listen. R. V. MOORTHY

Athlete support system

An increased focus on physical fitness has set India on course for consistent success, an elite panel of experts including John Gloster (Rajasthan Royals head physio), Dr. Tvisha Parikh (sports physician, Sir H. N. Reliance Foundation Hospital), Dr. Amit Bhattacharjee (scientist, PGIMER, Chandigarh), and Vijay Sharma (National weightlifting coach) discussed in a panel titled 'The Athlete Support System'.

"Possessing technical skills in any sport is crucial, but without matching physical capability, there can be inconsistency in performance. Take Indian hockey, for example. Despite being technically gifted over multiple generations, when the aspect of fitness was introduced, it faced challenges," said Gloster.

"Virat Kohli demonstrated that to achieve consistency in performance, prioritising fitness is essential."

Meanwhile, Sharma focused on mental training. "At the Rio Olympics, we were unable to clear a single clean and jerk attempt. This experience made me realise the importance of psychological support. That's not exclusive to athletes; coaches

also face pressure and must discover effective ways to cope with it." Dr. Parikh elaborated on the preventative benefits of sports medicine.

"While sports medicine certainly addresses injuries and their treatment, it extends beyond that narrow scope," Parikh said.

"Upon entering our development system, athletes undergo a thorough health examination. Any complaints are duly attended to establish a comprehensive baseline. This baseline enables us to anticipate and address potential future complications."

One of Olympic gold medallist Abhinav Bindra's closest confidants, Dr. Bhattacharjee was Bindra's personal mental trainer for over a decade and warns against neglecting this aspect.

"There should be an emergency mental training setup in place, particularly considering the harsh realities of sports like shooting. Imagine an athlete who has dedicated a decade of hard work, only for something to go wrong in the final moments, abruptly ending their four-year journey to the podium," Bhattacharjee said.

